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SYSTEM DESIGN · EXECUTION · INFLUENCE

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Leadership & Interview Story Bank

Prepared evidence for the questions Staff+ and engineering-leadership loops actually ask.

CORE NARRATIVE

I began in a small engineering team building custom .NET systems, learned enterprise cloud delivery at Perficient, co-led government ERP transitions at CGI, then moved into founder and technical-owner roles. The through-line is increasing scope: from implementing features, to migrating systems, to owning architecture and delivery, to designing AI platforms and creating teams around ambiguous customer problems.

FIVE STORIES TO MASTER

- TabX: designing a trustworthy AI-assisted resolution pipeline at ~22.5M-record scale.
- Royal: translating domain-heavy engineering work into a 95% faster production workflow.
- ATHENA/HERMES: turning AI-governance principles into concrete architecture and acceptance tests.
- MCP operating layer: creating leverage by replacing fragmented integrations with typed tools and shared context.
- Government ERP transition: coordinating technical and stakeholder work where correctness, readiness, and adoption mattered together.



Interview Story

How to use models without making them the system of record.

SITUATION

A heterogeneous POS dataset contained approximately 22.5 million units requiring normalization and mapping. Purely manual review could not scale; unconstrained model decisions would create silent data-quality risk.

TASK

Design a production architecture that maximized automated resolution while keeping uncertain decisions inspectable, reversible, and measurable.

ACTIONS

- Separated deterministic resolution from probabilistic assistance.
- Used embeddings and retrieval to narrow candidate space rather than treating generation as truth.
- Introduced model verification, confidence thresholds, and explicit review queues.
- Designed durable workflow and audit state across .NET, Python, SQL Server, React, and MCP interfaces.

RESULT

Created an architecture capable of operating at dataset scale while preserving human control over ambiguous cases. The strongest interview discussion is the tradeoff framework: precision versus coverage, automation versus review cost, and model capability versus operational trust.



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ROYAL · CUSTOMER OUTCOME

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Interview Story

From weeks of expert toil to minutes without erasing domain judgment.

SITUATION

Civil engineers manually transferred and reconciled settlement-model outputs into Excel workbooks and charts. The workflow took weeks, constrained throughput, and created QA/QC risk.

ACTIONS

- Mapped the actual engineering workflow and file semantics before selecting the implementation shape.
- Built PDF/PSO extraction, validation, Excel automation, and chart generation across .NET and React.
- Handled domain edge cases including stage/table count mismatches, optional naming prefixes, and missing day-zero values.
- Delivered in phases aligned with the client's schedules and test files.

RESULT

Supported up to 300 model outputs per upload, reduced the multi-week workflow to minutes, and documented a 95% cycle-time improvement.

LEADERSHIP LESSON

Automation earns trust when it preserves the expert's ability to validate the result. The goal was not to remove engineers from the process; it was to remove reconstruction work so they could spend time on engineering judgment.



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ATHENA · TECHNICAL VISION

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Interview Story

Turning an ethical concern into a testable system architecture.

PROBLEM

Student-success systems often collapse fragmented evidence into risk scores and recommendations, creating a veneer of precision while hiding sources, counter-evidence, missing data, and policy versions.

ARCHITECTURAL MOVE

Relocate the system's job from deciding what a student needs to assembling what a competent human needs to see. This produces a decision surface rather than an automated verdict.

ACCEPTANCE TESTS

- Sufficiency: can the human decide without reconstructing the world in other systems?
- Legibility: can every claim be traced to source and rule?
- Challengeability: can a person correct or override the system cheaply?
- Dignity: is risk represented as an attribute of a path rather than a person?
- Restraint: does the system stop before irreversible action?

STAFF-LEVEL SIGNAL

The story demonstrates first-principles product thinking, ontology design, governance, cross-functional communication, and the ability to turn abstract principles into falsifiable engineering criteria.



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OPENAI / ANTHROPIC / STAFF+ LOOPS

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Interview Preparation

What the package cannot substitute for.

TECHNICAL PREPARATION

- Practice coding with emphasis on clean interfaces, optimal complexity, tests, and verbal collaboration.
- Prepare two system designs: agent/tool platform and high-volume entity resolution.
- Be ready to draw data flows, failure modes, authorization boundaries, observability, evaluation, and rollback.
- Know the exact ownership boundary and current production maturity of every project.

LEADERSHIP PREPARATION

- Quantify team size, direct reports, contractors, budget authority, and decision scope precisely—do not imply what cannot be defended.
- Prepare examples of disagreement, changed judgment, failed approach, difficult feedback, and stakeholder conflict.
- Explain why moving from founder/consultant work into a top AI company increases the scale and quality of problems you can own.

COMPENSATION POSITIONING

A \$500K+ package generally maps to Staff/Principal impact or senior management at top-paying companies. The candidacy must establish organization-level leverage, not simply nine years of experience. Negotiate total compensation—base, equity, bonus, sign-on, refreshers, and level—after role fit and competing processes are real.